

Selection and Settlement of Pioneers

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THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

23 May 2016

To all National Spiritual Assemblies

Dear Bahá'í Friends,

You have by now received the pioneer call of the Universal House of Justice for the current Plan, in the letter dated 23 May 2016. Considering the vital responsibility that your institution bears to facilitate, in close collaboration with the Continental Counsellors, the flow of pioneers to intended destinations, we have been asked to convey the following.

As mentioned in that letter, over the last five years special initiatives were launched in ten regions of the world to support the growth and development of the Faith with the help of international pioneers. In each case, the House of Justice called upon specific National Spiritual Assemblies to identify, in consultation with the Counsellors, a few friends who might wish to participate. The ability of National Assemblies to quickly find, orient, and dispatch pioneers has been, in no small measure, a critical factor in the success of these initiatives. There is no doubt that new endeavours of this nature will be announced in this Plan, and it is the hope of the House of Justice that, when called upon, National Assemblies will demonstrate a similar expeditious response. Continental Pioneer Committees, which are fully cognizant of the requirements of each initiative, will, of course, be able to assist them by continuing to provide timely advice and resources in order to facilitate the movement of pioneers.

As a result of the systematic efforts of the friends who were involved in these endeavours, an approach has gradually emerged that has proven to be efficacious in reinforcing the process of growth in those countries where it has lagged. The main elements of this approach include the selection and settlement of pioneers; the appointment of one or more resource persons who work closely with the pioneers and local believers and assist with the strengthening of the training institute; the fostering of genuine friendships with a growing number of individuals, particularly from among the youth who are often invited to participate in youth gatherings where insightful conversations on the community-building process take place; the introduction of courses of the training institute and the ensuing multiplication of core activities, especially the junior youth programme; and the regular gathering of friends involved at the level of coordination in order to plan and to disseminate learning. While the approach outlined above has so far been applied in the context of international pioneering, in larger countries it could be implemented with similar effectiveness on the home front, in those regions that would greatly benefit from outside assistance in order to unlock the potential for growth.

It is expected that during this Plan many of those who will arise to serve in the field of pioneering will come from the ranks of the youth. In this connection, the pioneer call puts forward a suggestion that friends, especially from strong clusters, may wish to offer service for a short period during their extended holidays; indeed, some may be able to settle in a village or neighbourhood within a nearby cluster, buttressing the efforts of local inhabitants. All these friends will require not only your encouragement, but also the timely provision of guidance and resources. The movement of pioneers in support of activities within a cluster is, of course, but one strategy amongst others, albeit a vital one. The efforts of pioneers need to be complemented

through other means, such as visiting teams or institute campaigns, to ensure that the progress of the cluster proceeds uninterrupted.

Be assured of the prayers of the House of Justice at the Sacred Threshold that an outpouring of divine bestowals may reinforce your efforts to assist all who wish to respond to its call for pioneers and go forth, relying on the confirming power of Bahá'u'lláh, to serve His Cause both at home and in other lands.

With loving Bahá'í greetings,

Department of the Secretariat

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]